Background

For some time now, HealthRules has had BlueCard support that includes some Web Services. These Web Services were originally done for specific customers, and then added to the core product. These older services have nothing at all to do with what this document is about!

"BlueCard® is a national program that enables members of one Blue Plan to obtain health care services while traveling or living in another Blue Plan's service area. The program links participating health care providers with independent Blue Plans across the country, and in more than 200 countries and territories worldwide through a single electronic network for claims processing and reimbursement. The BlueCard® program allows you to submit claims for patients from other Blue Plans, domestic and international, to your local Blue Plan. Your local Blue Plan is your sole contact for claims payment, problem resolution and adjustments. "

How BlueCard works

The BlueCard program utilizes a set of proprietary services referred to as Inter-Plan Teleprocessing Services (ITS). These ITS services provide a set of common formats, software and procedures for communicating claims data among Plans. These are file bases loaders that run nightly.

The ITS formats most commonly used for claim processing are:

- Submission Format (SF) - From HOST to HOME - contains provider fee details
- Disposition Format (DF) - From HOME to HOST - contains benefit fee details
- Reconciliation Format (RF) - From HOST to HOME - contains final paid out fee details

Plans can use ITS to transmit submission claims data (SF), adjudicated claims data (DF) and paid claims data (RF) in formats that use common data elements, data element descriptions and record layouts. The ITS software also interfaces with a BCBSA proprietary network called "BluesNet®", which is used by Plans to transmit these formats from plan to plan.

In short, the BlueCard® program allows Providers across the country and worldwide to submit claims for Members enrolled outside of the Provider's local area:

1. The provider submits claims to their local plan (the HOST plan)
2. The HOST plan calculates the provider fee details
3. The HOST plan then sends the fee details as an SF to the "HOME" plan signifying that a member of their HOME saw a provider from the HOST and the fees that the provider is owned

4. The HOME plan calculates the benefit details, communicating with BlueCard's PX and APIC3 apps (these are MQ calls done every time a claim is adjudicated, including during Preview Result)
5. The HOME plan creates a DF to send to the HOST plan with the benefit details calculated
6. The HOST plan pays the provider using the values in the DF and sends a RF back to the HOME with what was paid out.
7. The HOME plan then pays the HOST plan back

Support High-level Overview

The customers are the first line of support and are expected to tell us when there are issues. The product design attempts to enable them to see problems themselves, and to enable them to react first. There are many possible "expected problems" and "normal exceptions" (more details below), and so customers are also expected to have tried to diagnose the problem themselves before contacting us, and to tell us what they have investigated.

Issues are expected to break down into these categories:

A claim-related, or business process-related issue, described something like "a claim did not update"

This should not become a Tier-1/Tier-2 Support issue until the user has validated where there was an error and tried to resolve it themselves. For example, if an SF update failed because someone had touched the claim when they shouldn't have, the customer should see that in the reported error, and they should have resolved that themselves. In such a case, HealthRules would detect the problem, stop processing the SF update, and raise the error. So, this is considered a "normal exception". The business process is for them to investigate and resolve. If they do investigate and then say, "we don't know what happened", then it will come to Support (this is now an issue that currently Susan in PS would triage).

A technical, architectural question like "Files are not transferring"

The BlueCard® customers expect that every day new claims data in the form of SF's, DF's and RF's will be coming into their system. If they don't get what they expect, they are going to raise an issue with us saying something like "We didn't get the SF's today." As HealthRules processes these files, and send out automated emails about the files that were processed to the customer.HealthEdge does not monitor if files are received or if they didn't process. Expectation is for HR to process the files it receives, and to receive files every day except holidays and Sundays (maybe not Saturday either, depending on the user). If customers don't get any files, or they don't get what they expect, they are going to raise an issue with us saying that they didn't get the SF's. For any errors, if HR had gotten a file, tried to process it

and hit an error at any point, that error goes into the email sent to customer, and they would have to provide HE with a copy of that email with the errors. So, our "trigger" to the users to look for errors is that email. They are supposed to monitor the emails (we do not). They also have internal reporting where they are looking for new claims data every day.

"MQ or APIC3 is down", or "We're getting an APIC3 error".

When a Payor user is trying to "Preview Results" or "Adjudicate" a claim, that processing involves a lot of MQ message traffic to/through the APIC3 server used to process SF/DF/RF data. If there are any MQ or APIC3 issues, or Payor is not communicating with APIC3, the claims get sent straight to the Work Basket where users can see these errors. The users are then going to report those errors to Support.

BlueCard Claim Flow Overview

HOST and HOME Plans

A BlueCard claim starts with a Member getting services from a participating Provider that is outside of the HOME plan's service area. The provider submits all claims to their local BCBS plan. When a BCBS plan receives a claim for a member from another plan, then the local BCBS plan of the Provider becomes the HOST plan for this claim. The Host plan will process the claim to get pricing for their provider and will then create a "Submission Format" (SF) claim transaction that it sends to the HOME plan. When the HOME plan receives the SF, they will process (reconcile) the claim and produce a "Disposition Format" (DF) transaction to send back to the HOST plan. The Host plan will receive the DF and use it to update their claims system and pay the provider. The HOST plan will create a "Reconciliation Format" (RF) and send it to the HOME plan to be reimbursed for paying the claim on their behalf.